



# Computing the GREEN way

New technology and better products hit the market every day. But what happens to the old PC, CD or printer that gets junked in favour of a new and better product?

VIDYARAMANAN S.

**H**ave you ever wondered what happened to that old 486 computer that once occupied pride of place in your dad's office? Did it ultimately end up in some landfill, or was it burnt in a rubbish dump, adding to the growing pollution in our world?

Approximately 20 million personal computers were discarded as obsolete in the year 1998. Most of these were dumped and just 6 per cent were recycled. Due to rapid developments in computing technology, the rate at which PCs are sold is increasing by 15 per cent rather than the estimated 5 per cent each year. The average age of a computer now ranges between three to five years. If PCs become obsolete at this rate and are not recycled, according to a study conducted by the Carnegie-Mellon University, there will be about 150 million PCs headed for landfills by the year 2005.

Needless to say, a PC is not a biodegradable

object. With sales of computers increasing and older ones being discarded for new pieces, we need to spare a thought as to how all the discarded machines are disposed of.

Taking heed of this, firms such as IBM, Dell and Sony have started recycle-and-reuse programmes aimed at reusing older equipment for producing new computer products. This reduces the need for raw materials required to produce new products and we gain resources that can be used for manufacturing other products. But most importantly, this means a healthier environment.

## Into the recycle bin

Disposing of computers by burning them or dumping them in landfills cause long-term damage to the environment. As a lot of toxic materials go into the production of PCs, burning them might release poisonous fumes into the atmosphere and if dumped into landfills, harmful